the help I could get. This was when I really needed Waqar to back me up.

Unfortunately, he hadn't let go of the past. Waqar and I had a history, dating all the way back to his tiff with Wasim over the captaincy crown. He was a mediocre captain but a terrible coach, always micromanaging and getting in the way, trying to tell the captain – me – what to do, and even dealing bilaterally with the players, poisoning their ears. We have different personalities and different leadership styles too. It was a natural clash and it was bound to happen.

More importantly, I was let down. Teaming up with the manager, Intikhab Alam, Waqar started lobbying against me. He targeted the board and chairman. Ijaz Butt – who earlier in his tenure was very supportive of me – also fell victim to Waqar's propaganda. I was sacked while I was playing county, *after* having won the West Indies series. Nobody called or consulted me.

I couldn't believe it. My 'personality' – which was to put my foot down when schedules and training got too gruelling for the guys – was critiqued. I was deemed 'psychologically unfit' for the job. What hurt even more was that none of the guys I had stood up for previously had my back. Nobody came out to support me. When I decided to challenge the decision in court, I was all alone. Meanwhile, I was getting angry. Very angry. And it was beginning to show in my public and media interactions.

The plot was driven by Waqar Younis. Apparently, *he* was the most threatened by my approach towards the game. As I gained more respect in the squad, Waqar as coach kept losing ground. But instead of fixing his own approach, he criticized mine and started encouraging the same old bickering, partisan culture that had split up the dressing room earlier. What he didn't realize was that being vulgar, even cheap, with the guys wouldn't earn him respect. Respect earns respect, not shooting the breeze and cracking dirty jokes.

I think it's fair to say that when our rather infamous disagreements started, Waqar – or Wiqi bhai as we all call him – and I were both at fault. We learnt a lot about each other during that tense phase, when all sorts of reports, some true and some exaggerated, came out about how we personally attacked each other with harsh words and tried to get each other fired. At the same time, we also got to know that some people exploited our tension and enjoyed our altercation. It's painful to realize that sometimes the people you stand up for end up stabbing you in the back. But I won't take any names. Not here.

Frankly, I'm an emotional man. As captain, my mantra has always been: if my players are happy, I am happy. I believe that the guys who are treated in a fair manner and are happy off the field will do well when they're on the field. If I don't step up for them out there, they will let themselves and even the country down when we're playing in the middle. It was our disagreement on those tenets that was broadly the root of my problem with Waqar.

My conflict with him started somewhat like this. Without a doubt, Wiqi bhai is a legend of the game, with a reputation that is well deserved. As a paceman, he was a demigod. As a captain, somewhat more mortal. But when he was appointed coach, he fell: the guys who listened to me somehow didn't seem to listen to him, and vice versa. That was largely the premise of our conflict. Frankly, it could have been easily resolved through honest and open dialogue, and a united captain–coach front, had it not been for the various third parties that wanted us to clash.

As a captain, all I expected of Wiqi bhai was to help me and back me up as coach. What I didn't want was for him to take me on and confront me. In my view, the coach–captain dynamic should be about coach plus captain, not coach versus captain. That's just a personal opinion and I